

"It was my first trip abroad. I used to train on the Sirukalathur ground, and the club helped me reach Spain and then Sweden. I haven't been in touch with football for a while, but I hope to return as a coach and train the children there in the near future," said Rishish.

"That was the turning point. That is when my father, D. Hari Krishnan, realised that through football we could send our youth abroad and help them build better lives," said his son Sivaraman, managing director and one of the club's coaches, who holds an AFC C Diploma.

"Education is essential, but it does not come naturally to everyone. In villages like ours, where most of the youth study in government schools, we wanted to help them build a career through sport," he added.

The club's progress, however, was gradual. It took five years to enter the Kancheepuram District League's third division, before moving up to the second division, just as momentum was building. Then came the COVID-19 pandemic.

"The pandemic can be considered a turning point for Sirukalathur Football Club," said Sivaraman.

A different approach

With schools shut and routines disrupted, many children were confined to their homes. The absence of structure soon began to show.

Coming from a family deeply involved in sport, Hari Krishnan and Sivaraman, along with Sai Krishnan, a former Under-15 Chennaiyin FC captain, noticed a worrying shift. With little supervision, several youngsters were beginning to drift towards unhealthy habits, including smoking, alcohol and, in some cases, substance abuse.

"We started focusing on children born between 2008 and 2012 and brought in new players. It was not easy, but by 2021 and 2022, we were among the better-performing grassroots clubs in Chennai," said Sivaraman.

In 2022, Bengaluru FC scouted players in Siruseri, and one from Sirukalathur earned a place at the all-India trials at the Inspire Institute of Sport in Bellary.

"Players from across the country attended the five-day camp, and Sanjay from our U-13 group was selected. He trained with Bengaluru

FC for an entire year," said Sivaraman.

In the years since, the pathway has become clearer. Seven players have moved to Chennaiyin FC's youth teams, one to Bengaluru FC, and two to FC Madras, while others have stepped into first-division football.

Yet, barriers remain. Training camps and trials are often held in cities and, for families dependent on daily wages, travel and stay can be prohibitive.

To address this, the club turned its focus towards All India Football Federation (AIFF) academy accreditation, a pathway that would allow its players to compete in youth leagues without having to leave the village in search of opportunities.

In 2024, the club applied and received a one-star rating, falling short of eligibility for youth leagues. It reapplied the following year and secured a two-star accreditation.

"It is something we dreamt of as a club," said Sivaraman.

"My brother and I both played for Chennaiyin FC at different stages, and we always wanted our own academy to compete at that level. It felt like a dream come true."

